

Synod of Laodicea (363 A.D.)

The Synod of Laodicea (363 A.D.)

The **Council of Laodicea** was a regional Christian synod of approximately thirty clerics from Asia Minor which assembled about 363–364 in Laodicea, Phrygia Pacatiana. The major concerns of the council involved regulating the conduct of church members. The council expressed its decrees in the form of written rules or canons. Among the sixty canons decreed, several aimed at:

- Maintaining order among bishops, clerics and laypeople (canons 3–5, 11–13, 21–27, 40–44, 56–57)
- Enforcing modest behavior of clerics and laypeople (4, 27, 30, 36, 53–55)
- Regulating approach to heretics (canons 6–10, 31–34, 37), Jews (canons 16, 37–38) and pagans (canon 39)
- Outlawing the keeping of the Sabbath (Saturday), and encouraging rest on Sunday (canon 29)
- Outlining liturgical practices (canons 14–20, 21–23, 25, 28, 58–59)
- Restrictions during lent (canons 45, 49–52)
- Admission and instruction of catechumens and neophytes (canons 45–48)
- Specifying a biblical canon (canons 59–60)

The 59th canon forbade the readings in churches of uncanonical books. The 60th canon listed canonical books, with the New Testament containing 26 books, omitting the Book of Revelation, and the Old Testament including 22 books from the Tanakh and several deuterocanonical books including I and II Esdras, the Book of Baruch, and the Epistle of Jeremiah. It is also believed that they may have demonized the “Second Book of Enoch”, which led to its degeneration. Around 350, [Cyril of Jerusalem](#) produced a list of biblical books matching that from the Council of Laodicea.

The Synod of Laodicea (363 A.D.)

THE CANONS OF THE SYNOD HELD IN THE CITY OF LAODICEA, IN PHRYGIA PACATIANA, IN WHICH MANY BLESSED FATHERS FROM DIVERS PROVINCES OF ASIA WERE GATHERED TOGETHER:

Source. *Translated by Henry Percival. From Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, Second Series, Vol. 14. Edited by Philip Schaff and Henry Wace. (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1900.)*

The holy synod which assembled at Laodicea in Phrygia Pacatiana, from various regions of Asia; set forth the ecclesiastical definitions which are hereunder annexed.

CANON 1

It is right, according to the ecclesiastical Canon, that the Communion should by indulgence be given to those who have freely and lawfully joined in second marriages, not having previously made a secret marriage; after a short space, which is to be spent by them in prayer and fasting.

CANON 2

They who have sinned in various particulars, if they have persevered in the prayer of confession and penance, and are wholly converted from their faults, shall be received again to communion, through the mercy and goodness of God, after a time of penance appointed to them, in proportion to the nature of their offense.

CANON 3

He who has been recently baptized ought not to be promoted to the sacerdotal order.

CANON 4

They who are of the sacerdotal order ought not to lend and receive usury, nor what is called hemioliaë.

CANON 5

Ordinations are not to be held in the presence of hearers.

Balsamon: "This canon calls elections "laying on of hands," and says that since in elections unworthy things are often said with regard to those who are elected, therefore they should not take place in the presence of any that might happen to come to hear."

CANON 6

It is not permitted to heretics to enter the house of God while they continue in heresy.

CANON 7

Persons converted from heresies, that is, of the Novatians, Photinians, and Quartodecimans, whether they were catechumens or communicants among them, shall not be received until they shall have anathematized every heresy, and particularly that in which they were held; and afterwards those who among them were called communicants, having thoroughly learned the symbols of the faith, and having been anointed with the holy chrism, shall so communicate in the holy Mysteries.

CANON 8

Persons converted from the heresy of those who are called Phrygians, even should they be among those reputed by them as clergymen, and even should they be called the very chiefest, are with all care to be both instructed and baptized by the bishops and presbyters of the Church.

CANON 9

The members of the Church are not allowed to meet in the cemeteries, nor attend the so-called martyrries of any of the heretics, for prayer or service; but such as so do, if they be communicants, shall be excommunicated for a time; but if they repent and confess that they have sinned they shall be received.

CANON 10

The members of the Church shall not indiscriminately marry their children to heretics.

CANON 11

Presbytides, as they are called, or female presidents, are not to be appointed in the Church.

CANON 12

Bishops are to be appointed to the ecclesiastical government by the judgment of the metropolitans and neighbouring bishops, after having been long proved both in the foundation of their faith and in the conversation of an honest life.

CANON 13

The election of those who are to be appointed to the priesthood is not to be committed to the multitude.

CANON 14

The holy things are not to be sent into other dioceses at the feast of Easter by way of eulogiæ

CANON 15

No others shall sing in the Church, save only the canonical singers, who go up into the ambo and sing from a book.

CANON 16

The Gospels are to be read on the Sabbath [i.e. Saturday], with the other Scriptures.

CANON 17

The Psalms are not to be joined together in the congregations, but a lesson shall intervene after every psalm.

CANON 18

The same service of prayers is to be said always both at nones and at vespers.

CANON 19

After the sermons of the Bishops, the prayer for the catechumens is to be made first by itself; and after the catechumens have gone out, the prayer for those who are under penance; and, after these have passed under the hand [of the Bishop] and departed, there should then be offered the three prayers of the faithful, the first to be said entirely in silence, the second and third aloud, and then the [kiss of] peace is to be given. And, after the presbyters have given the [kiss of] peace to the Bishop, then the laity are to give it [to one another], and so the Holy Oblation is to be completed. And it is lawful to the priesthood alone to go to the Altar and [there] communicate.

CANON 20

It is not right for a deacon to sit in the presence of a presbyter, unless he be bidden by the presbyter to sit down. Likewise the deacons shall have worship of the subdeacons and all the [inferior] clergy.

CANON 21

The subdeacons have no right to a place in the Diaconicum, nor to touch the Lord's vessels.

CANON 22

The subdeacon has no right to wear an orarium, nor to leave the doors.

CANON 23

The readers and singers have no right to wear an orarium, and to read or sing thus [habited].

CANON 24

No one of the priesthood, from presbyters to deacons, and so on in the ecclesiastical order to subdeacons, readers, singers, exorcists, door-keepers, or any of the class of the Ascetics, ought to enter a tavern.

CANON 25

A subdeacon must not give the Bread, nor bless the Cup.

CANON 26

They who have not been promoted [to that office] by the bishop, ought not to adjure, either in churches or in private houses.

CANON 27

Neither they of the priesthood, nor clergymen, nor laymen, who are invited to a love feast, may take away their portions, for this is to cast reproach on the ecclesiastical order.

CANON 28

It is not permitted to hold love feasts, as they are called, in the Lord's Houses, or Churches, nor to eat and to spread couches in the house of God.

CANON 29

Christians must not judaize by resting on the Sabbath, but must work on that day, rather honouring the Lord's Day; and, if they can, resting then as Christians. But if any shall be found to be judaizers, let them be anathema from Christ.

CANON 30

None of the priesthood, nor clerics [of lower rank] nor ascetics, nor any Christian or layman, shall wash in a bath with women; for this is the greatest reproach among the heathen.

CANON 31

It is not lawful to make marriages with all [sorts of] heretics, nor to give our sons and daughters to them; but rather to take of them, if they promise to become Christians.

CANON 32

It is unlawful to receive the eulogiæ of heretics, for they are rather ἀλογίαι [*i.e.*, follies], than eulogiæ [*i.e.*, blessings].

CANON 33

No one shall join in prayers with heretics or schismatics.

CANON 34

No Christian shall forsake the martyrs of Christ, and turn to false martyrs, that is, to those of the heretics, or those who formerly were heretics; for they are aliens from God. Let those, therefore, who go after them, be anathema.

CANON 35

Christians must not forsake the Church of God, and go away and invoke angels and gather assemblies, which things are forbidden. If, therefore, any one shall be found engaged in this covert idolatry, let him be anathema; for he has forsaken our Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, and has gone over to idolatry.

CANON 36

They who are of the priesthood, or of the clergy, shall not be magicians, enchanters, mathematicians, or astrologers; nor shall they make what are called amulets, which are

chains for their own souls. And those who wear such, we command to be cast out of the Church.

CANON 37

It is not lawful to receive portions sent from the feasts of Jews or heretics, nor to feast together with them.

CANON 38

It is not lawful to receive unleavened bread from the Jews, nor to be partakers of their impiety.

CANON 39

It is not lawful to feast together with the heathen, and to be partakers of their godlessness.

CANON 40

Bishops called to a synod must not be guilty of contempt, but must attend, and either teach, or be taught, for the reformation of the Church and of others. And if such an one shall be guilty of contempt, he will condemn himself, unless he be detained by ill health.

CANON 41

None of the priesthood nor of the clergy may go on a journey, without the bidding of the Bishop.

CANON 42

None of the priesthood nor of the clergy may travel without letters canonical.

CANON 43

The subdeacons may not leave the doors to engage in the prayer, even for a short time.

CANON 44

Women may not go to the altar.

CANON 45

[Candidates] for baptism are not to be received after the second week in Lent.

CANON 46

They who are to be baptized must learn the faith [Creed] by heart, and recite it to the bishop, or to the presbyters, on the fifth day of the week.

CANON 47

They who are baptized in sickness and afterwards recover, must learn the Creed by heart and know that the Divine gifts have been vouchsafed them.

CANON 48

They who are baptized must after Baptism be anointed with the heavenly chrism, and be partakers of the Kingdom of Christ.

CANON 49

During Lent the Bread must not be offered except on the Sabbath Day and on the Lord's Day only.

CANON 50

The fast must not be broken on the fifth day of the last week in Lent [i.e., on Maunday Thursday], and the whole of Lent be dishonoured; but it is necessary to fast during all the Lenten season by eating only dry meats.

CANON 51

The nativities of Martyrs are not to be celebrated in Lent, but commemorations of the holy Martyrs are to be made on the Sabbaths and Lord's days.

CANON 52

Marriages and birthday feasts are not to be celebrated in Lent.

CANON 53

Christians, when they attend weddings, must not join in wanton dances, but modestly dine or breakfast, as is becoming to Christians.

CANON 54

Members of the priesthood and of the clergy must not witness the plays at weddings or banquets; but, before the players enter, they must rise and depart.

CANON 55

Neither members of the priesthood nor of the clergy, nor yet laymen, may club together for drinking entertainments.

CANON 56

Presbyters may not enter and take their seats in the bema before the entrance of the Bishop: but they must enter with the Bishop, unless he be at home sick, or absent.

CANON 57

Bishops must not be appointed in villages or country districts, but visitors; and those who have been already appointed must do nothing without the consent of the bishop of the city. Presbyters, in like manner, must do nothing without the consent of the bishop.

CANON 58

The Oblation must not be made by bishops or presbyters in any private houses.

CANON 59

No psalms composed by private individuals nor any uncanonical books may be read in the church, but only the Canonical Books of the Old and New Testaments.

CANON 60

These are all the books of Old Testament appointed to be read: 1, Genesis of the world; 2, The Exodus from Egypt; 3, Leviticus; 4, Numbers; 5, Deuteronomy; 6, Joshua, the son of Nun; 7, Judges, Ruth; 8, Esther; 9, Of the Kings, First and Second; 10, Of the Kings, Third and Fourth; 11, Chronicles, First and Second; 12, Esdras, First and Second; 13, The Book of Psalms; 14, The Proverbs of Solomon; 15, Ecclesiastes; 16, The Song of Songs; 17, Job; 18, The Twelve Prophets; 19, Isaiah; 20, Jeremiah, and Baruch, the Lamentations, and the Epistle; 21, Ezekiel; 22, Daniel.

And these are the books of the New Testament: Four Gospels, according to Matthew, Mark, Luke and John; The Acts of the Apostles; Seven Catholic Epistles, to wit, one of

James, two of Peter, three of John, one of Jude; Fourteen Epistles of Paul, one to the Romans, two to the Corinthians, one to the Galatians, one to the Ephesians, one to the Philippians, one to the Colossians, two to the Thessalonians, one to the Hebrews, two to Timothy, one to Titus, and one to Philemon.

